

WILD & CO VOYAGES · ECUADOR · 0°45′S 90°19′W

# The Galápagos Islands, *Read in Order of Age*

*A field guide to Galápagos cruises, land journeys and wildlife, island by island*

PREPARED FOR

**Jane Traveler**

TRAVELER FOLIO · JW-F-0001

COVER · SEA LION, SANTA FE · PHOTO PIKAIA LODGE GALÁPAGOS

A LETTER BEFORE YOU GO

# Dear Jane,

*I first came here in 1991, and I still remember the feeling: I was Darwin. A small airport, a handful of boats in the whole archipelago, no guide at my elbow, and almost no one else going. You stepped off the panga and the islands simply carried on, sea lions asleep on the landing, boobies nesting on the path, a hawk close enough to touch, none of them the least bit bothered by us.*

*I've kept going back ever since, and the reason hasn't changed. The animals still don't care that we're there. The rock is still being made in the west and worn down in the east, so every island is a different chapter. And every time I go, I see something I walked straight past the time before. It's the one place I know where you come home more curious than when you left.*

*Today far more people come, so how you go matters. Small ships, the right season, and a naturalist who has been doing this for decades. That's what this guide is for. Start with the rock, read the islands oldest to youngest, and the wildlife makes sense.*

*This guide is page one of your Folio. Mark it up. Circle what makes you grin. Cross out what doesn't. When we talk, I'll already know which kind of traveler you are.*

*J. Wild* CHIEF EXPEDITION OFFICER · FIRST LANDED 1991

I KEEP GOING BACK
since 1991

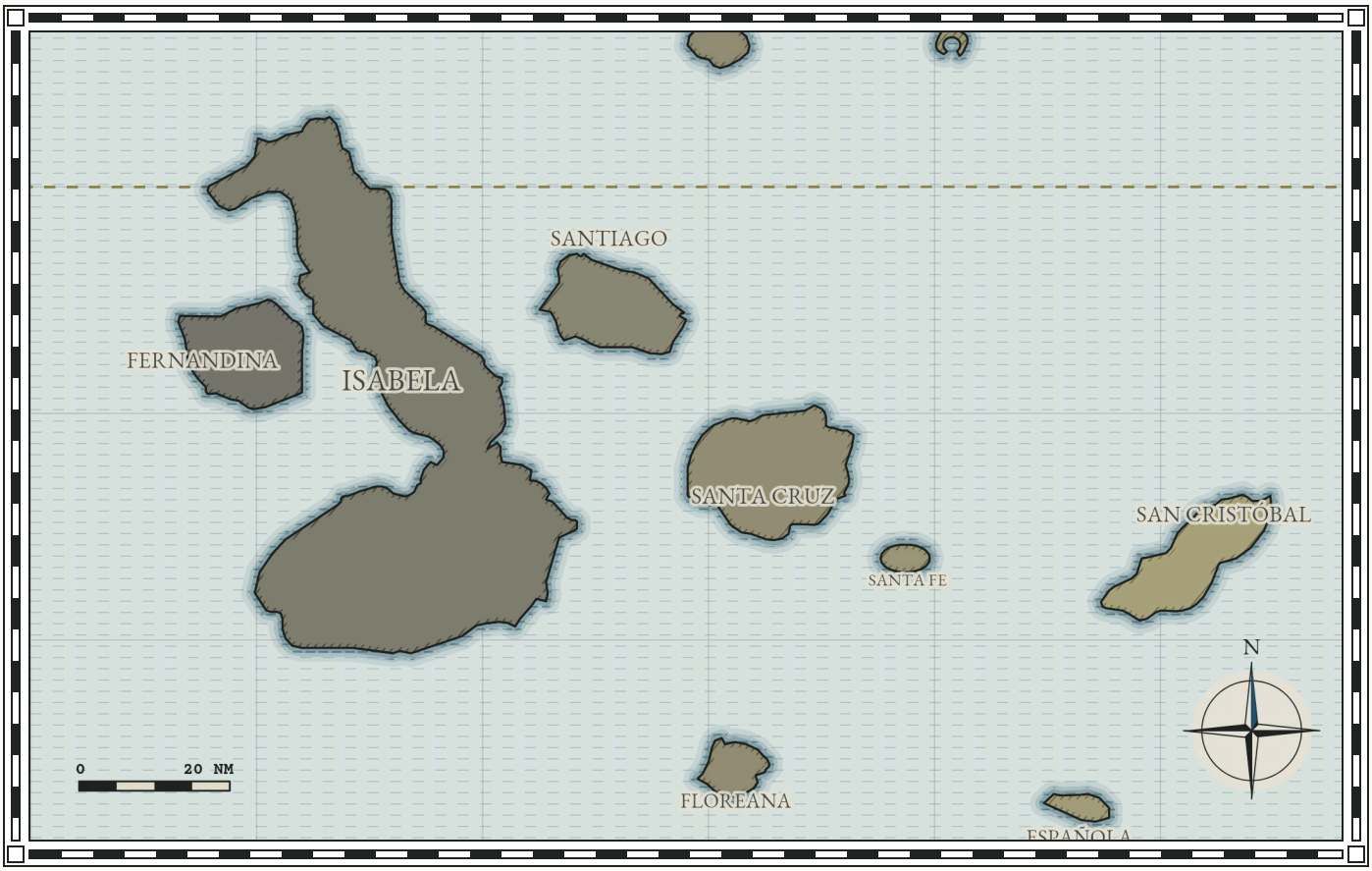
| | 1991, when I first came | Today |
|---|---|---|
| VISITORS | Fewer than 50,000 a year (early 1990s) | About 330,000 a year (2023) |
| THE WAY IN | A small airport and a handful of boats | Daily flights, busy harbour towns and a long list of licensed ships |
| THE ANIMALS | Unafraid | Still unafraid. That's the miracle. |

## How to read the marks in this guide

Every place, ship and lodge carries one stamp from the Ledger. It tells you exactly how well we know it. Nothing gets a stamp it hasn't earned.

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| I KNOW A PLACE<br>*I slept here* | James has stayed there himself. | I'VE WALKED IT<br>*vetted on foot* | Inspected in person, every path and room. |
| I KEEP GOING BACK<br>*founder favourite* | The places James returns to on his own time. | I KNOW THE HOST<br>*the house patches you in* | A personal introduction comes with the booking. |
| I KNOW WHO KNOWS<br>*partner vetted* | Vetted through a partner we trust, like Royal Galapagos. | I'LL KNOW SOON<br>*well worth the visit* | On James's list. Recommended, honestly marked. |

# A conveyor belt you can stand on




◀ YOUNGER · WEST · well under a million years

OLDER · EAST · roughly 3-4 million years ▶



*The oldest residents keep the slowest schedule. Take the hint.*

Photo: Pikaia Lodge

## Wildlife without fear

Animals here evolved without hunters on land, and they still behave like it. You'll step around sea lions, not stalk them.

## Geology you can read

Old islands in the east are worn and green; young ones in the west are black lava and still active. Sail one to the other and you watch the place being made.

## A park that says no

The National Park sets every landing and time. Fewer people at each site, a naturalist with every group, and rules that keep it this way.

**LINGER LONGER** *"Give the islands enough days to tell the story in order. Five days is a trailer." — J. W.*

# Never trust a brochure with no weather in it

| | J | F | M | A | M | J | J | A | S | O | N | D |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Season** | warm | warm | warm | warm | warm | garúa | garúa | garúa | garúa | garúa | garúa | warm |
| **Sea (approx.)** | 24–26° | 24–26° | 24–26° | 24–26° | 24–26° | 19–22° | 19–22° | 19–22° | 19–22° | 19–22° | 19–22° | 24–26° |
| **Albatross, Española** | · | · | · | ● | ● | ● | ● | ● | ● | ● | ● | ● |
| **Best for** | snorkel | snorkel | snorkel | snorkel | snorkel | wildlife | wildlife | wildlife | wildlife | wildlife | wildlife | snorkel |

DECEMBER – MAY

## The warm season

Warmer water, calmer seas, green highlands and short showers. The snorkeler's choice.

JUNE – NOVEMBER

## The garúa season

The Humboldt Current brings cool water, misty mornings and the richest marine life. Rougher crossings, livelier wildlife.



*Blue-footed boobies: the dance is real, and it is not for you*

Photo: Pikaia Lodge

> *There's no bad month. There's only the month that suits you. Tell me whether you'd rather be warm or wowed, and I'll tell you when to go.*
> *– J. Wild*

Wildlife timing is approximate and varies by year; your naturalist confirms on the day.



*A pile of marine iguanas. The collective noun is a mess. Accurate.*

# Who the Galápagos is for, and who it isn't

The short answer: almost anyone curious, and nobody in a hurry. Here's how I'd match you, by the kind of traveler you are. My notes are in the margin, as always.

**BEST FOR**
Curious people who like animals more than shopping

**IDEAL LENGTH**
8 to 15 days; 5 is a trailer

**BEST TIME**
Any month. Dec–May warm and calm, Jun–Nov cooler and wilder

**HOW**
Small ship, land lodge, or both

## MADE FOR YOU IF YOU'RE…

### First-timers
*Come for the tortoises, leave rewriting your bucket list.*
OUR PICK · THE CONTRAST · 9 DAYS, LAND THEN SEA

### Families, kids about 8 and up
*The only classroom where the homework naps on your towel.*
OUR PICK · PIKAIA BY LAND, OR TAKE THE WHOLE YACHT

### Couples & honeymooners
*Romantic, though the blue-footed boobies will out-dance you.*
OUR PICK · SEA STAR BALCONY SUITE, CRUISE A

### Snorkelers & divers
*Penguins on the equator. You'll stop trying to explain it.*
OUR PICK · CRUISE C · THE YOUNG WEST

### Photographers
*For once the problem is the animals are too close.*
OUR PICK · ESPAÑOLA & GENOVESA

### Three generations
*Grandparents on the sundeck, kids in the water, everyone at dinner.*
OUR PICK · CHARTER THE WHOLE YACHT

### Solo travelers
*Sixteen guests. You'll leave with fifteen friends.*
OUR PICK · SEA STAR · ASK ABOUT SINGLE RATES

## THINK TWICE IF YOU'RE…

### Bad sailors
*The Pacific doesn't read itineraries.*
OUR PICK · SLEEP ASHORE AT PIKAIA; DAY BOATS ONLY

### Night owls
*Lights out around nine. The stars are the after-party.*
OUR PICK · ADD TWO NIGHTS IN QUITO

### Beach loungers
*The beaches are perfect, and already taken by sea lions.*
OUR PICK · PAIR IT WITH ONE OF OUR BEACH STAYS

### Anyone in a hurry
*Five days is a trailer. You came for the film.*
OUR PICK · STRETCH TO THE FULL CIRCLE

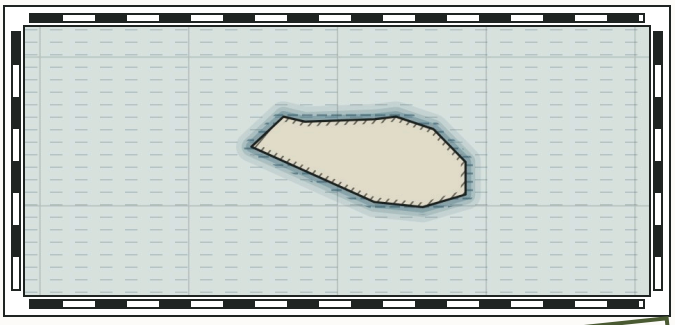
### Limited mobility
*Wet landings, lava underfoot, pangas that bob.*
OUR PICK · PIKAIA AND THE GENTLER SITES; TELL US AND WE'LL PLAN AROUND IT

Minimum ages and landing rules vary by ship [confirm per program]. If you're not sure where you fit, that's what the call is for.



*Never in a hurry. Take the hint.*

# Six islands worth the crossing



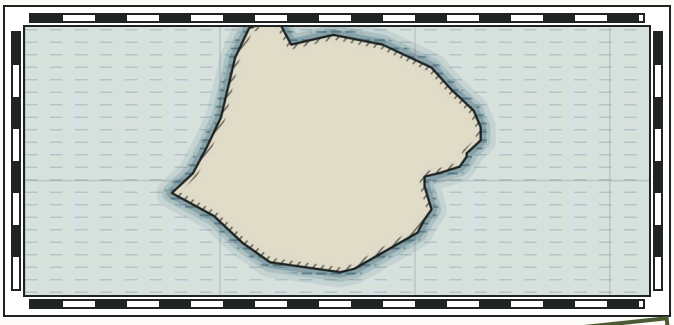
## Española

I'VE WALKED IT

*The elder*

Waved albatross (about Apr–Dec), the Suárez blowhole, sea lions on Gardner Bay.

Dry & wet landings · Cruise A



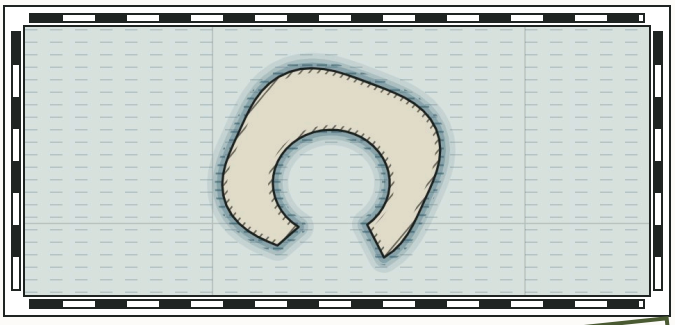
## Floreana

I'VE WALKED IT

*Pirates and post*

Flamingos at Cormorant Point, snorkelling Devil's Crown, the Post Office Bay barrel.

Wet landings · Cruise A



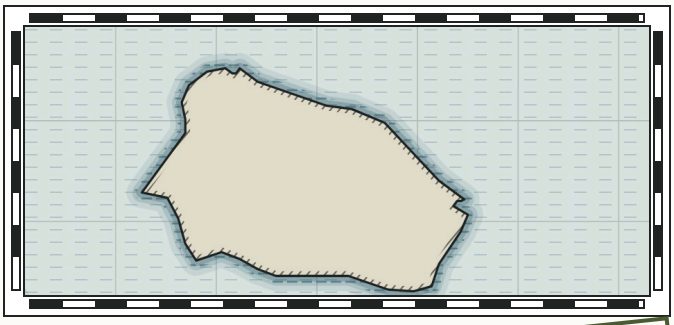
## Genovesa

I'VE WALKED IT

*The bird island*

Red-footed boobies, frigatebirds, storm petrels and, with luck, short-eared owls.

Dry & wet landings · Cruise B



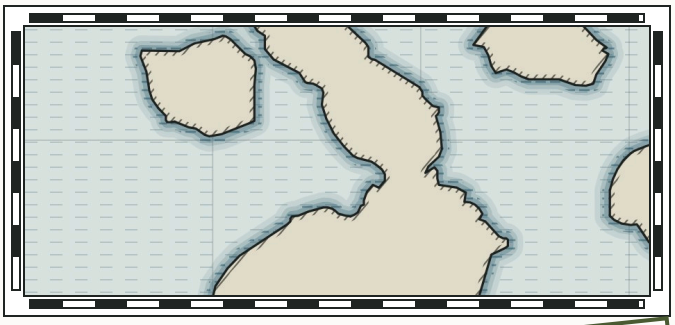
## Santiago & Bartolomé

I'VE WALKED IT

*The lava fields*

Pinnacle Rock from the summit, fresh pāhoehoe at Sullivan Bay, fur seals at Egas Port.

Dry & wet landings · Cruises B & C



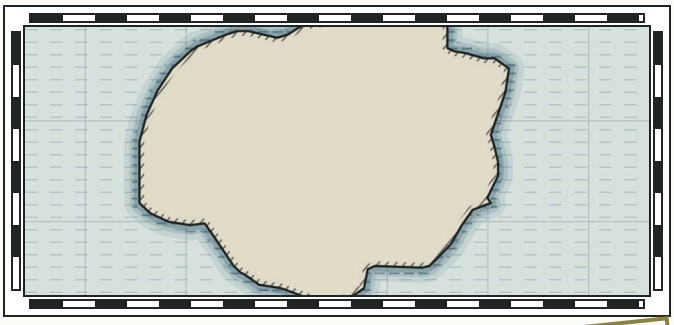
## Isabela & Fernandina

I'VE WALKED IT

*The young west*

Marine iguanas by the hundred, flightless cormorants, penguins on the equator.

Dry & wet landings · Cruise C



## Santa Cruz

I'LL KNOW SOON

*The highlands*

Wild tortoises in the cloud forest, the breeding center, and Pikaia Lodge on the volcano.

Road & day boat · All journeys

Sample stamps for layout. James confirms each island's mark before release.

IV · TWO WAYS TO SEE IT

# By sea, by land, or both

| | BY SEA · SEA STAR | BY LAND · PIKAIA LODGE | BOTH · THE CONTRAST |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Where you sleep** | One suite that moves with you | One room on the Santa Cruz highlands, about 1,500 ft up | Three nights ashore, then the ship |
| **Reach** | The whole archipelago, incl. Genovesa & Fernandina | Islands near Santa Cruz by day yacht; no overnights at sea | Central islands, then the far west |
| **Pace** | Two landings a day | Day trips, then home to the lodge | Slow, then deep |
| **Sea legs** | Night crossings | Sleep on land every night | Land first, sea once you're ready |
| **Suits** | Wildlife purists, solo travelers, charters | Families, poor sleepers at sea, hikers | First-timers with time |
| **Nights** | 4–14 | 3 or more | 3 + 5 |
| **From** | $[____] pp | $[____] pp | $[____] pp |



*Your own deck for the passing islands* Photo: Royal Galapagos



*A balcony king room: the bed that doesn't move* Photo: Pikaia Lodge

## The linger-o-meter

The same archipelago at three speeds. What each adds, and what you miss without it.

**5**

DAYS · CRUISE B

Genovesa's birds, Bartolomé's view, the highlands.

*You miss: the old south, the young west.*

**9**

DAYS · THE CONTRAST

Highlands and tortoises, then Isabela and Fernandina.

*You miss: Española's albatross.*

**15**

DAYS · THE FULL CIRCLE

Oldest to youngest, all three routes, one suite.

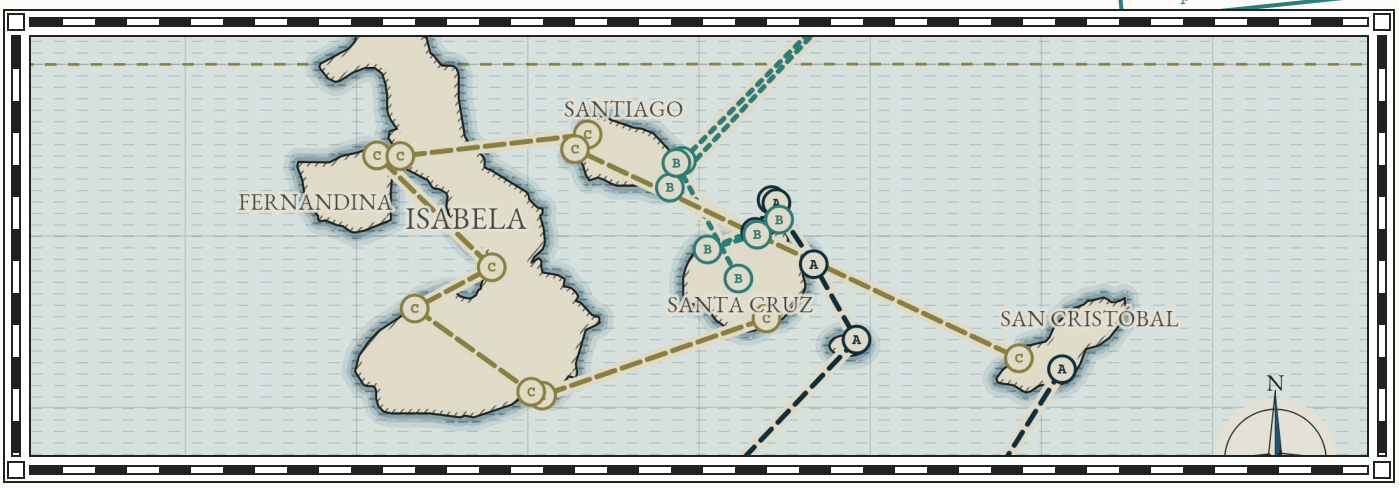
*You miss: nothing but the office.*

LINGER LONGER *"The third day is when the animals stop being a surprise and start being neighbours." — J. W.*

# Oldest to Youngest

JW-VYG-004 · GALÁPAGOS SEA STAR · 16 GUESTS · 8 SUITES · WITH ROYAL GALAPAGOS

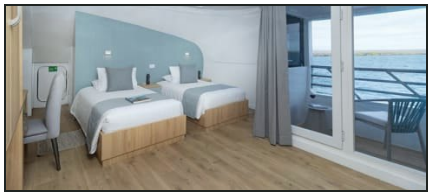
I KNOW WHO KNOWS
*partner vetted*




*Cruise A — — the old south · Cruise B · · · the north · Cruise C — — the young west*



*The Galapagos Sea Star, our Oldest to Youngest voyage yacht* Photo: Royal Galapagos



*Balcony suite: worth it for the 6 a.m. light alone* Photo: Royal Galapagos



*Fire & Frigatebirds: the courtship display that names a voyage* Photo: Pikaia Lodge

| | |
|---|---|
| A | **Tue–Sun · The Old South.** San Cristóbal, Española, Floreana, Santa Fe, South Plaza, North Seymour. |
| B | **Sun–Thu · Fire & Frigatebirds.** Dragon Hill, Black Turtle Cove, Genovesa, Bartolomé, the highlands. |
| C | **Thu–Tue · The Young West.** Isabela, Sierra Negra, Elizabeth Bay, Fernandina, Santiago, Lobos. |
| A+B+C | **15 days · The Full Circle.** All three, back to back, one suite. Guests change at Baltra; you stay aboard. |

WHO IT SUITS

Wildlife purists, solo travelers, families, and groups who take the whole yacht (8 suites, 16 guests).

FROM

**$[_____] pp · 4 nights**

TIME REWARDED

Sail the Full Circle: [__]% off the third leg.

`TR-GAL-JW-F-0001`

QR

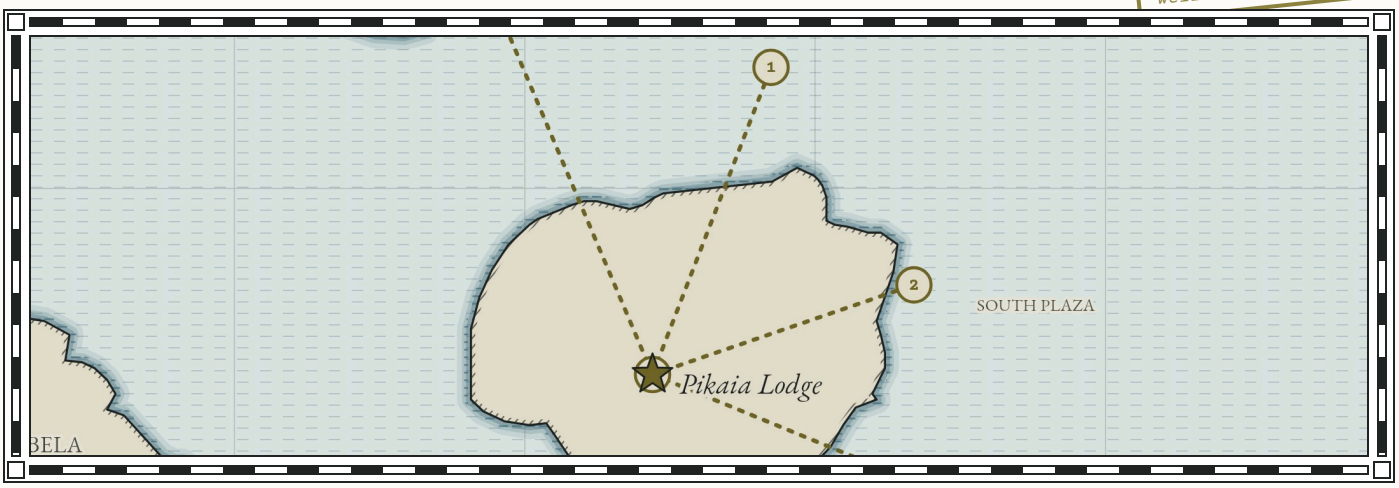
Scan for the live animated chart of this route.

LINGER LONGER *"If you can only do one, do the one with Fernandina in it." — J. W.*

# Highlands & Day Boats

SAMPLE LAND JOURNEY · PIKAIA LODGE, SANTA CRUZ · 14 ROOMS · ABOUT 1,500 FT UP

I'LL KNOW SOON
well worth the visit




*Day trips by the lodge's own yacht · sample sites, set by the lodge and the Park*



*Highlands & Day Boats: the lodge sits on the rim of two extinct craters* Photo: Pikaia Lodge



*Sleep in one bed, see the islands by day boat* Photo: Pikaia Lodge



*The sea lion will find you. Let it.* Photo: Pikaia Lodge

| | |
|---|---|
| Day 1 | **Up the volcano.** Land at Baltra, drive to the highlands. Tortoises on the lodge trails by evening. |
| Day 2 | **North Seymour by yacht.** Frigatebirds and blue-footed boobies at nesting distance; back for dinner. |
| Day 3 | **South Plaza & Santa Fe.** Land iguanas and a snorkel stop. |
| Day 4 | **Bartolomé.** The summit view over Pinnacle Rock. |
| Day 5 | **Garrapatero.** Bike to the beach, then fly home. |

The lodge yacht runs day trips only, so it reaches the islands near Santa Cruz. For Genovesa or Fernandina, see the Contrast.

WHO IT SUITS

Families, travelers who sleep badly at sea, hikers, and anyone who wants one room for the whole stay.

FROM

$[_____] pp · 4 nights

WORTH ANOTHER NIGHT

A fourth night at Pikaia: [offer to confirm].

WAN-GAL-JW-F-0001

QR

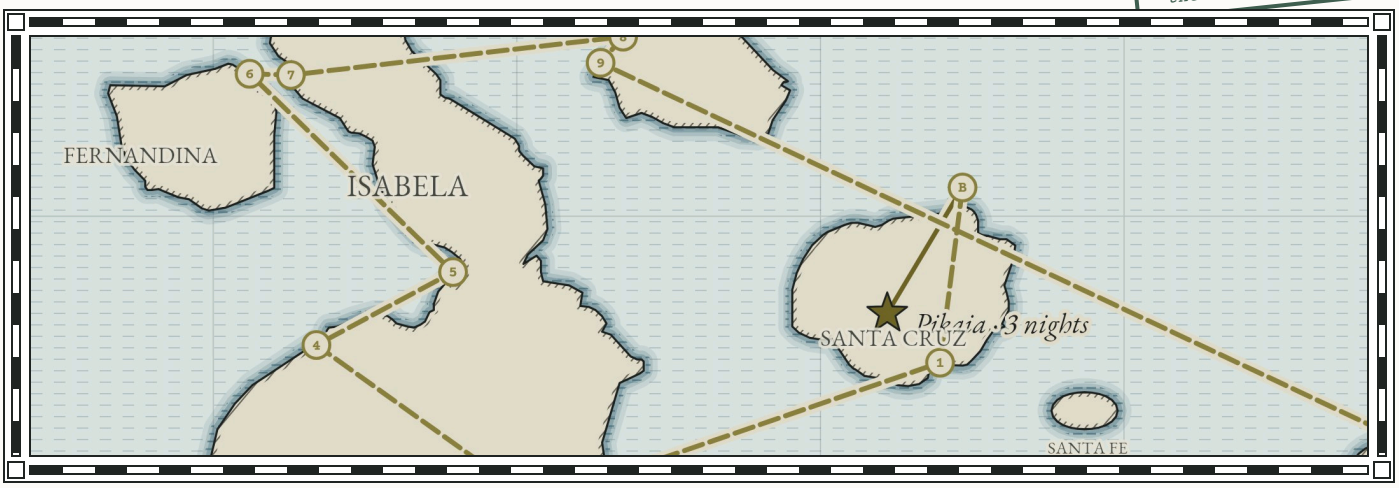
Scan for the live animated chart of this route.

LINGER LONGER *"Wake up to tortoises, fall asleep without a single wave. Some people call that cheating. I call it smart." — J. W.*

# The Contrast

JW-CON-G01 · 3 NIGHTS AT PIKAIA, THEN CRUISE C ABOARD THE SEA STAR · 9 DAYS

HOUSE FAVOURITE
*the James Wild way*




*Pikaia Lodge, three nights · then Cruise C west to Isabela and Fernandina*



*Worth Another Night, earned at the pool* Photo: Pikaia Lodge



*The sundeck, best seat for frigatebirds riding the mast* Photo: Royal Galapagos



*The only lizard on earth that swims for its supper* Photo: Pikaia Lodge

| | |
|---|---|
| Mon | **Arrive Baltra.** Up to Pikaia; tortoises before dinner. |
| Tue–Wed | **Day boats from the highlands.** North Seymour, then Bartolomé or the Plazas. |
| Thu | **Board the Sea Star.** Cruise C begins at Baltra; the breeding center that afternoon. |
| Fri–Mon | **The young west.** Isabela, Fernandina, Santiago. |
| Tue | **Lobos Island, fly home.** From San Cristóbal. |

WHO IT SUITS

First-timers with nine days, couples, and anyone nervous about a first night at sea.

FROM

**$[____] pp · 8 nights**

THE CONTRAST RATE

Land plus sea, priced together: [__].

CON-GAL-JW-F-0001

QR

Scan for the live animated chart of this route.

LINGER LONGER *"Good journeys have seams. Land, then sea. You should feel the change." — J. W.*

# Every boat we'd put you on

Each can be chartered whole, 4 to 15 days, with naturalists, crew and every meal. Sixteen to twenty guests means every one of you is on the first panga.



## Galapagos Sea Star

I KNOW WHO KNOWS

YACHT · LUXURY · 16 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Our Oldest to Youngest yacht. Two jacuzzis, triple and connecting cabins.



## Galapagos Horizon

I'LL KNOW SOON

TRIMARAN · LUXURY · 16 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

A balcony in every cabin. Three hulls for the channel crossings.



## Infinity

I'LL KNOW SOON

YACHT · LUXURY · 20 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Two bilingual naturalists and balconies throughout. Good for big families.



## Natural Paradise

I'LL KNOW SOON

YACHT · LUXURY · 16 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Upper-deck balcony suites plus a main-deck suite.



## Grand Majestic

I'LL KNOW SOON

YACHT · LUXURY · 16 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

A true master suite. The one for an anniversary charter.



## Galapagos Angel

I'LL KNOW SOON

YACHT · FIRST CLASS · 16 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Two upper-deck suites and a friendlier price.



## Calipso

I'LL KNOW SOON

YACHT · FIRST CLASS · 16 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Cabins across three decks. Solid, unfussy, well run.



## Origin · Theory · Evolve

I'LL KNOW SOON

EXPEDITION YACHTS · 20 GUESTS · 10 STATEROOMS · ECOVENTURA

Three sister yachts. Pick by itinerary, not by name.



## Hermes

I'LL KNOW SOON

MEGA CATAMARAN · 2025 · 20 GUESTS · 12 SUITES · VIANATURA

164 feet, 20 crew, two butlers. The new benchmark for a whole-ship charter.

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**CHARTER THE WHOLE SHIP** *"Take the whole boat and the itinerary becomes a conversation, not a brochure."*

*— J. W.* `Charter rates from $[____]`

Photos: Royal Galapagos, Ecoventura, Vianatura. Marks are samples until confirmed.

VI · LINGER

# Slower is the whole point



*Worth Another Night, earned at the pool* Photo: Pikaia Lodge

## Most Galápagos regrets are about time, not money. People fly a long way, see one route, and spend the flight home wondering about the other islands. We'd rather you stayed.

That's why the house sets a three-night minimum on land, and why our offers reward staying longer rather than booking sooner.

*Three nights or don't bother. Night one you unpack. Night two you notice. Night three the place starts talking.*
*– J. Wild*

TIME REWARDED

Sail the Full Circle

15 days, one suite, `[__]%` off the third leg.

**TR-GAL-JW-F-0001**

WORTH ANOTHER NIGHT

A fourth night at Pikaia

`[offer to confirm with the lodge]`

**WAN-GAL-JW-F-0001**

ON THE HORIZON

Not this year? Next.

2028 departures with early-planner savings of `[__]`.

**OTH-GAL-JW-F-0001**

Codes are tied to your Folio ID so your advisor sees which offer you chose.



*Green turtles swim right under you, mildly curious at most.*

VII · THE LEDGER

# The Galápagos entries

| ENTRY | PLACE | MARK | MARGIN NOTE |
|---|---|---|---|
| L-101 | Galápagos Sea Star · Royal Galapagos | I KNOW WHO KNOWS | *Sixteen guests. The naturalist decides, and is usually right.* |
| L-102 | Pikaia Lodge · Santa Cruz highlands | I'LL KNOW SOON | *On the list for my next run west.* |
| L-103 | Española · Suárez Point | I'VE WALKED IT | *Albatross from April. Bring patience and a hat.* |
| L-104 | Genovesa · El Barranco | I'VE WALKED IT | *The bird island. Long lens, short sleeves.* |
| L-105 | Fernandina · Espinoza Point | I'VE WALKED IT | *Younger than some of your relatives.* |

Sample entries for layout. Every stamp is confirmed by James before release.

## Rules of the Road

01 **The smaller the boat, the bigger the sea.** First ashore, last back.

02 **Read a place in the order it was written.** Old islands first.

03 **Arrive the day before the day before.** Mainland flights run late; ships don't wait.

04 **Contrast beats coverage.** Land, then sea. You'll feel the change.

## Words we've struck out

~~LUXURY CRUISE~~ — It's a yacht with sixteen guests and a naturalist who knows every sea lion by its scars.

~~HIDDEN GEM~~ — Nothing here is hidden. It's protected. Different thing.

~~ONCE IN A LIFETIME~~ — Most of our guests come back. I



*Giant tortoises at feeding time. Slower than you think, and grumpier.*

# What to know, and what not to expect

## Getting there

Fly to Guayaquil or Quito, then on to Baltra or San Cristóbal. Plan a night on the mainland first.

## Fees at the door

Galápagos National Park entrance fee `[US$200 adult, confirm]` and Transit Control Card `[US$20, confirm]`.

## Fitness

Wet landings from pangas, uneven lava, short hikes in the sun. Tell us about knees and backs; we'll match the route.

## Pack

Reef-safe sunscreen, a brimmed hat with a strap, water shoes, a light layer for garúa mornings, a dry bag, and a long lens if you have one.

## What not to expect

| | |
|---|---|
| ~~CASINO~~ | The only gamble is whether the penguins show up. |
| ~~FORMAL NIGHTS~~ | Dress code: dry by dinner. |
| ~~YOUR OWN LANDING TIMES~~ | The Park sets the clock. Everyone keeps it. |
| ~~HAND-FEEDING~~ | Two metres from wildlife. The animals didn't get the memo. |
| ~~STRONG WI-FI~~ | Limited at sea `[confirm]`. Post the photos at home. |

## Straight answers

**Sea or land first time?** Sea reaches more; land sleeps better. The Contrast does both.

**Solo?** Welcome on both. Ask about the single supplement.

**Children?** Strong fit. Age guidance `[confirm per program]`.



*Brown pelicans, the harbour's unpaid security.*

YOUR TRAVELER FOLIO · JW-F-0001

# Your journey, in your hand

**When I'd like to go**

**Who's coming**

**Sea, land or both** ☐ Sea Star ☐ Pikaia ☐ The Contrast

**The island I circled**

**Something to celebrate**

QR · LIVE CHART

## Watch the route before you book

Scan to open the animated chart of your route: the globe, the flight in, the yacht from anchorage to anchorage.

I KNOW A PLACE · THE WEEKLY LETTER

### One place a week, from James's own book

New vessels, quiet anchorages and the odd secret we don't print here. You're already on the list.

A LAST WORD FROM JAMES

*Jane, that's the Galápagos as I've come to know it since 1991. Circle what moves you, cross out what doesn't, and send it back to me. I'll read every mark and call you with a plan built around them. The islands have waited a few million years. They can wait for you to get it right.*

*Til our next expedition,*

*James*

JAMES PAPAGNO · CHIEF EXPEDITION OFFICER


## JAMES WILD & CO.

james@jameswildco.com · 561.479.6355 · jameswildco.com/voyages

FL Seller of Travel ST45327 · IATAN 10783883 · Journey design since 1982


**PHOTOGRAPHS** Royal Galapagos (Galapagos Sea Star, Horizon, Infinity, Natural Paradise, Grand Majestic, Angel, Calipso); Pikaia Lodge Galápagos; Ecoventura (Origin, Theory, Evolve); Vianatura (Hermes). Used with the permission of our partners.
**ILLUSTRATIONS** Watercolour field sketches from a traveller's Galápagos journal, May 2024 [artist to confirm], used with permission. Cover islands redrawn from an antique map, Galápagos Isles (to Ecuador) [source to confirm].
**MAPS** Engraved plates drawn by James Wild & Co. from Natural Earth public-domain data; Genovesa and Santa Fe outlines approximate.
**SOURCES** Visitor figures: C. Hunt, "The Galápagos Islands," in Overtourism (early 1990s); Galápagos Insiders, citing official figures (2023). Fees, seasons and wildlife timing are guidance only; your naturalist and the Galápagos National Park have the final word.
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